

the U.S. for the first three seasons. By the end of the fourth season, it was the number one show in America on Friday nights. I'm particularly proud of its popularity among teens.

Lucky for you, my goal is to keep you out of that 40th percentile. I want to help you understand that your romantic relationship is a business transaction. Marriage is a contract. It's no different than the deals I make on *Shark Tank* or *Dragons' Den*: both sides commit to working together toward a mutually agreed-upon end. Because I would never invest in a business before performing due diligence, I'm going to suggest you take the same approach.

We have an internal document that we use at O'Leary Ventures: a thorough questionnaire we ask every company to complete. I've modified the checklist so that it's applicable to you and your relationship. I'm not saying you have to slam a Relationship Due Diligence checklist down in front of every person you date—but I'm also not saying that's a bad idea, especially when things get serious. I've been doing this in business for a while now, and believe me when I say the truth will always come out in the end. Better to know it now than suffer the consequences later.

RELATIONSHIP DUE DILIGENCE

The best way to get your partner to fill out a Relationship Due Diligence checklist is to ask outright. Don't soft-shoe around it; simply explain that you take this relationship seriously and, before you go any further, you need to respectfully ask some financial questions and you'd appreciate your partner's honest replies. If you like, you can offer to fill out a checklist yourself first. Clear off a table and sit down together with all your financial documents—bank statements, tax returns, credit scores, etc. If you want to take the pressure off, do it over a glass of wine. This stuff doesn't have to be a big deal, and some of the answers you may already know; but if your prospective partner has a tantrum, well, that should tell you something. Make it clear to your partner that this process is only going to bring you closer as a couple. Financial intimacy starts here.